led International agencies to focus their attention on protecting and sustaining the biosphere.

In 1971, UNESCO launched the Man and the Biosphere Programme to study our impact on nature and how it could be minimized. Even after several decades the programme still continues to shape the future of sustainability of the earth.

7.2 Biosphere

The word Biosphere originates from the Greek words bios = life and sphaira = sphere. Earth is the only planet in the solar system that supports life. There are many reasons that contribute to this and the most important being the earth's distance from the sun, the presence of oxygen in the atmosphere and the presence of water. The above factors, along with the existence and interaction of the three spheres of the earth (the lithosphere, hydrosphere and atmosphere) gives rise to the fourth sphere which is the life sphere or biosphere (Figure 7.1). The term *Biosphere* was coined by **Eduard Suess** in 1875. Later contributions to the study of biosphere were from, **Charles Darwin** and many other scientists.

Thus, in the biosphere, life exists on land, water and air and life forms range from microorganisms to plants, animals, birds, amphibians, reptiles and mammals including human beings.

The biosphere is formed of biotic components. It consists of *organisms, population, community* and *ecosystem*.

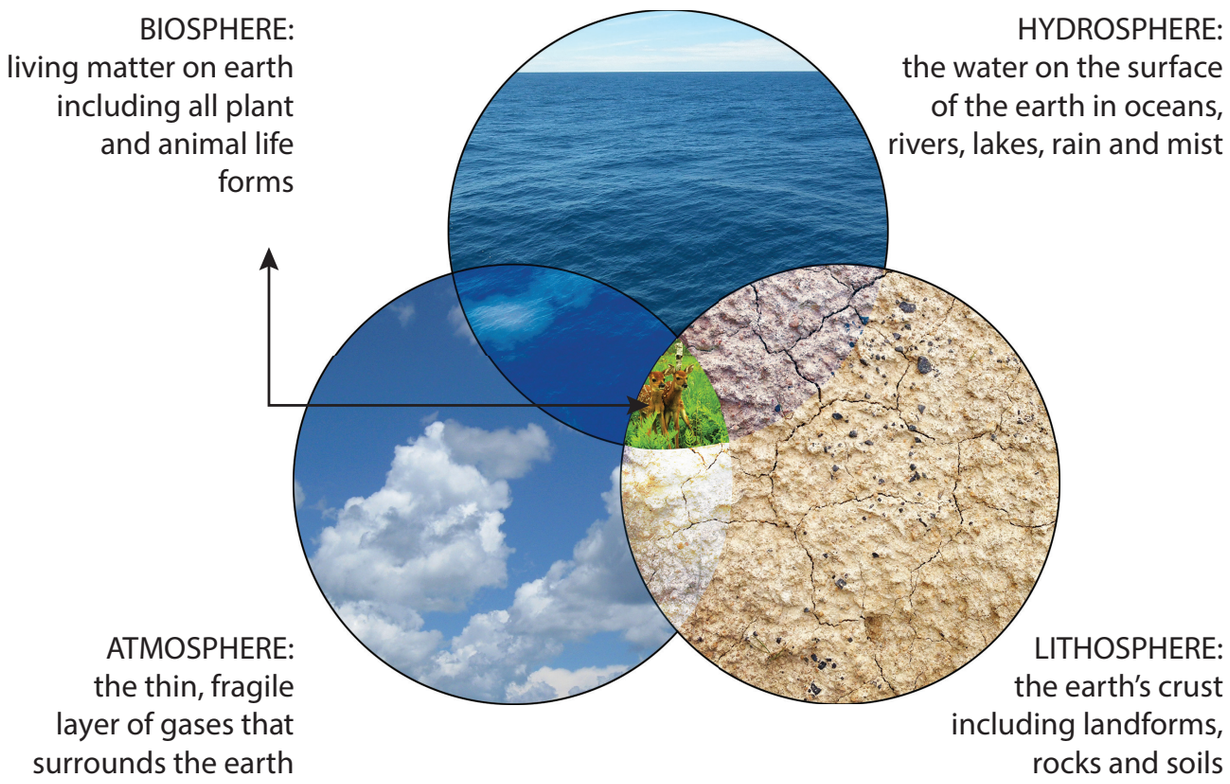


Figure 7.1 Biosphere

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